was eleven years senior to me and his post had normally been held by the senior-most deputy director until that point. I was not yet even a deputy director, and in fact it took me another six months to be promoted to that rank. It appeared that my one and a half years' association with Suntook as assistant director (personnel division) in 1972-73, before my posting to Gangtok as Officer on Special Duty (police) when Suntook was joint director (establishment), had created a favourable impression, which had led him to take that unusual decision. It took me some time to settle in the new job, which also required liaising with the MEA at a suitable level (normally with the director, establishment).

Emergence of Bhindranwale

As mentioned earlier, during the nearly two years ending January 1980 when Indira Gandhi returned to power, nothing significant was achieved in Punjab by the 1 Akbar Road gang through Op-1. However, during the general elections, Bhindranwale actively campaigned for three Congress candidates – Punjab State Congress party chief R.L. Bhatia from Amritsar, Sukhbans Kaur Bhinder (wife of Pritam Singh Bhinder, a senior IPS officer who played a controversial role during the Emergency and was later appointed DGP, Punjab) from Gurdaspur, and former speaker (1969–1971, 1971–1975) of Lok Sabha, Gurdial Singh Dhillon, from Tarn Taran. The fact that Bhindranwale had by then become a well-known figure in Punjab would be evident from the fact that two Congress candidates contesting the elections had specifically mentioned in their election posters: 'Bhindranwale supports me'. [11]

It appears that Indira Gandhi never met Bhindranwale alone. However, Janata Party candidate Pran Nath Lekhi, who contested the 1980 elections against Sukhbans Kaur Bhinder from the Gurdaspur constituency, alleged that 'Mrs Gandhi herself actually appeared on the same platform as Bhindranwale in the election campaign'. [12]

In their book *Amritsar: Mrs Gandhi's Last Battle,* Mark Tully and Satish Jacob write: 'Following the official denial after Bhindranwale's death that Mrs Gandhi or the Congress Party had